



Maritime &
Coastguard
Agency

Guidance

MSN 1796 (M+F) Amendment 4: Vessel Traffic Services - Designation of Vessel Traffic Service (VTS) centres in the United Kingdom

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Summary

1. This notice identifies and designates UK VTS for the purpose of requiring compliance by shipping with regulations 6 and 7 of the Merchant Shipping (Vessel Traffic Monitoring and Reporting Requirements) Regulations 2004, implementing European Parliament and Council Directive 2002/59/EC.
2. Provides the formal identification of UK vessel traffic services (VTS) within UK waters for the benefit of the compliance of shipping with the Regulations and SOLAS Chapter V, Regulation 12.
3. VTS contributes to safety of life at sea, safety and efficiency of navigation and protection of the marine environment, adjacent shore areas, work sites and offshore installations.

1. Statutory requirements

1.1 Regulation 2(1) of the Merchant Shipping (Vessel Traffic Monitoring and Reporting Requirements) Regulations 2004 (the “2004 Regulations”) defines a vessel traffic service as a service:

(a) Which is designed to improve the safety and efficiency of vessel traffic and to protect the environment and which is capable of interacting with

that traffic and responding to traffic situations developing in the VTS area;
and

(b) Which, in relation to a service operated by the United Kingdom, either alone or in conjunction with one or more States, is a service provided from within the United Kingdom which has been designated by the MCA in writing and is specified in a Merchant Shipping Notice (MSN).

1.2 This notice is the Merchant Shipping Notice to which those Regulations refer.

1.3 Services which are designated for the purposes of the 2004 Regulations are listed in the annex to this MSN.

1.4 Where the MCA designates a VTS, which is operated in accordance with IALA Guidelines and MGN 401 (as amended), those vessels which are subject to the 2004 Regulations must comply with the rules of that VTS.

2. Application

The Rules of the 2004 regulations apply to all ships except:

1. all ships less than 300 gross tonnage;
2. warships, naval auxiliaries and other ships owned or operated by the Government of an EEA State which are used for non-commercial public service;
3. fishing vessels having a length of less than 45 metres;
4. traditional ships having a length of less than 45 metres;
5. recreational craft having a length of less than 45 metres.

However all vessels irrespective of size and type may be required to comply with VTS rules within port limits because of local port legislation.

3. Rules of the VTS

3.1 When passing through a VTS area, ships shall make reports and respond to calls on the designated radio channel for that VTS.

3.2 Additional “rules” for each designated VTS are in the Admiralty List of Radio Signals (ALRS) Volume 6 part.

4. Maintenance of standards in accordance with MCA Guidelines

4.1 The authority identified in the designation is responsible for ensuring that the VTS is operated in accordance with IALA Guidelines and MGN 401 (as amended).

5. Requests by port authorities to become “designated” VTS

5.1 Application is made by the authority to the MCA at the address given at the end of this notice. The MCA will inform the authority if MCA officials intend to visit the VTS Centre, and will confirm in writing whether the VTS is designated or if the MCA intends to remove or amend details of an existing designation.

5.2 Designation by the MCA will be subject to the receipt of:

1. Confirmation by the port and VTS authority that the VTS will be operated in accordance with the MGN 401 (as amended).
2. Satisfactory details about the VTS; and
3. Confirmation of the statutory UK powers required for operation of the VTS in question.

6. Promulgation of information on designated VTS

6.1 Ships cannot be expected to comply unless the VTS is properly identified and information on additional rules is made fully available by the normal means of promulgating such information to the mariner.

6.2 Service provision and the rules of the VTS should follow the guidance given in MGN 401 (as amended) and IALA Guideline 1089. This information will be issued by VTS Authorities and published in the Admiralty List of Radio Signals Volume 6 part 1 updated in Weekly Notice to Mariners.

6.3 Any changes to the list of designated VTS Centres will be published in an amended version of this notice.

More Information

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Southampton SO15 1EG

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Website Address: www.gov.uk/government/organisations/maritime
(<http://www.gov.uk/government/organisations/maritime-and-coastguard-agency>)

General Inquiries: infoline@mcga.gov.uk

Please note that all addresses and telephone numbers are correct at time of publishing

Annex 1: Designated VTS centres

- Aberdeen
- Belfast
- Bristol
- Channel Navigation Information Service
- Dover Port
- Forth and Tay Navigation Service

- Harwich Haven
- Humber Estuary
- Liverpool
- London Port Control Centre (Gravesend)
- London Thames Barrier (Woolwich)
- Medway
- Milford Haven
- Southampton & Nab
- Orkney
- Peterhead
- Plymouth
- Poole
- Portsmouth
- Sullom Voe
- Sunk
- Tees and Hartlepool
- Tyne



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